



Working Backwards

Week 1 • Day 2 • Customer-Centric Foundations

Technical Product Manager Academy



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- Apply Day 1 prompts to accelerate PR/FAQ drafting and critique
- Run a structured peer critique of another triad's PR/FAQ



Today's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:15	Opening	Recap Day 1, set up FieldPulse stretch case
09:15 – 10:30	Block 1 + Activity 1	Forward vs Backward thinking
10:45 – 12:00	Block 2 + Activity 2	PR/FAQ structure, headline drafting
13:00 – 14:15	Block 3 + Activity 3	The Five Customer Questions
14:30 – 16:00	Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts	Peer critique + revision

Block 1 — Why Work Backwards?

The feature factory problem and the fix



The Feature Factory Pattern

❌ Forward-built product

- Idea → spec → build → ship
- "Customer value" asserted, not tested
- Launch reveals whether it was needed
- Re-work paid for in production

✅ Backward-built product

- Imagine the launch → write the PR → answer the FAQ
- Customer value is *written down* first
- If the PR is weak, the product is weak
- Re-work paid for in writing

The shift: We do not use documents to plan what we'll build. We use them to *decide whether to build at all*.



Where Working Backwards Came From

Amazon formalized the **PR/FAQ** process in the early 2000s. Teams wrote a press release *before* the product existed, answered the FAQs an exec would ask, and used the document as the meeting agenda for "should we do this?"

Why it spread: It reliably kills weak ideas early, surfaces the hard questions on paper (where answers are cheap), and forces alignment before a single engineer is staffed.

Activity 1 — Forward or Backward?

Triads • 30 minutes

Each triad receives 4 short vignettes describing how a real (anonymized) product was conceived. Decide: was this forward-built or backward-built? What's the evidence?

- Two of the four are misleading — read carefully
- For each, write the *one* question that, if asked earlier, would have changed the outcome



15 min analyze · 15 min full-room debrief

Block 2 — The PR/FAQ Structure

Anatomy of the document that kills bad ideas



One-Page PR — Six Parts

#	Section	Purpose
1	Heading	Product + audience in one line a customer would read
2	Sub-heading	Concrete benefit in customer language
3	Summary paragraph	The story, in 3-4 sentences, as if launched
4	Problem paragraph	The pain before your product existed
5	Solution paragraph	How your product removes the pain — mechanism explicit
6	Customer quote	A fictional but credible customer — if you can't write it believably, the PR fails

A FieldPulse PR — Working Sketch

FieldPulse launches "End-of-Day Reconcile" — 5-minute close-outs for HVAC dispatchers

Small-business HVAC dispatchers can now close their day in five minutes instead of 45, using a guided reconcile flow that pulls truck inventory, tech timecards, and parts usage into one approval screen.

Dispatchers at 50-to-200-technician shops typically stay 45 minutes past close every night reconciling paper tickets, truck stock, and timecards.

FieldPulse's new End-of-Day Reconcile pulls these into a single guided flow, flags anomalies, and submits the day in under five minutes.

"I used to leave after my kids were in bed. Last week I made it home for dinner four nights in a row." — Maria R., Lead Dispatcher, Reliable Climate Co.



The FAQ Side

Customer FAQ

- How much does it cost?
- What if my truck inventory is wrong?
- Can I use it offline?
- How does it know what parts were used?

Internal FAQ

- What's the riskiest assumption?
- What's the build estimate? On what evidence?
- What breaks if adoption is 30% of plan?
- What existing integrations block this?

Rule: If you can't write the internal FAQ, you don't understand the product yet. Go back to the PR.

Activity 2 — Headline + Sub-headline

Triads • 45 minutes

Each triad selects one product idea (from their Day 1 critique artifacts, or a provided list). Draft **three** candidate heading + sub-headings. Then use AI to critique each:

- "Which of these would a dispatcher actually click on?"
- "Which promises something we can't deliver?"
- "Which is interchangeable with a competitor's marketing?"



15 min draft · 15 min AI critique · 15 min pick + justify

Block 3 — The Five Customer Questions

The diagnostic under every PR/FAQ

? Five Questions That Force Clarity

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3. **What is the most important benefit?** One benefit. If you list three, you don't have one yet.

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5. **What does the experience look like?** Describe the moment, not the feature.

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Common Failure Modes

Failure	Symptom	Fix
Generic customer	"Small business owners"	Name the role, size, and context
Category problem	"Inefficient workflows"	Replace with a verb the customer uses
Benefit bouquet	"Faster, better, cheaper"	Choose one. Defend it.
Handwave evidence	"Customers told us"	Cite <i>who, when, what tier</i>
Feature description	"A dashboard with..."	Describe the human moment of use

Activity 3 — Answer the Five, Concretely

Triads • 45 minutes

Your triad has a headline/sub-headline from Activity 2. Now draft a full PR paragraph + customer quote + 3 Customer-FAQ + 3 Internal-FAQ entries.

- Use Day 1's research + summarization prompts to ground each claim
- Tag every claim with an evidence tier (**Observed** , **Reported** , **Inferred** , **AI-generated**)
- Be honest — unvalidated is fine today, but it must be *labeled*

 10 min plan · 25 min draft · 10 min self-review

Block 4 — Peer Critique & Revision

How to review without rewriting someone else's work

The Critique Protocol

Critique runs on a timed protocol so every author gets balanced feedback:

1. **2 min silent read** — reviewer highlights 1 line they love, 1 they question
2. **3 min "What I heard"** — reviewer restates the product to the author in one sentence
3. **5 min questions only** — reviewer asks, author listens and takes notes (no defending)
4. **5 min author response** — author says what they'll change, what they'll leave

Why "questions only": It forces reviewers to reveal what confused them rather than prescribing a fix. It respects the author's ownership.

Activity 4 — Cross-Triad PR/FAQ Review

Paired triads • 60 minutes • Readouts

Triads pair up. Using the critique protocol, each triad reviews the other's PR/FAQ. Then 15 minutes to revise.

- One critique from each failure-mode table cell
- Capture which evidence tier needs to be upgraded before Friday
- Each triad does a 60-second readout: *"What we changed and why"*



20 min review A • 20 min review B • 15 min revise • 5 min readout



Day 2 Wrap

What we built

- A complete one-page PR/FAQ per triad
- The Five Customer Questions as a working checklist
- A critique protocol we'll reuse every week

What opens tomorrow

- **Personas** — we take "Who is the customer?" from a sentence to a validated artifact
- Your PR/FAQ customer quote becomes persona input on Day 3

Bring to Day 3: Your PR/FAQ + the one unvalidated assumption you're most worried about.

Questions & Reflection

Which of the Five Questions was hardest for your triad?